

Academic art

From the 17th to the 19th century, the art academies of Europe wielded great power in the art world. Students aspired to join them, exhibit with them and win competitions, but to do this, they had to conform to strict demands.

The Académie des Beaux-Arts in Paris was the most important, awarding the Prix de Rome, a fellowship to study at the Académie Française in Rome. Entrants had to be French, male, under 30 and single. Exhibitions included the annual Paris Salon where exhibits were selected by a strict panel who favoured a certain style. Synthesizing the careful contours of Neoclassicism and (if painting) the intense colours of Romanticism, Academic art (also called Academism or L'Art Pompier) had a highly refined style and moralistic tone. Brushstrokes or carved marks had to be imperceptible, the hierarchy of subjects had to be adhered to. Among the greatest exponents were Jean-Léon Gérôme (1824–1904), William-Adolphe Bouguereau (1825–1905), Thomas Couture (1815–79) and Hans Makart (1840–84).



Bouguereau, *The Birth of Venus*, 1879